

HYROX Youngstars

Coach Education — Knowledge Base

This document contains the original text from the HYROX Youngstars coach education curriculum, structured for AI-assisted assessment. Images and infographics from the source have been converted to equivalent text and tables. No wording has been altered.

What is HYROX?

To coach young athletes effectively, you must understand the ecosystem behind the sport. This module introduces you to the full HYROX universe: its origins, global growth, race format, movement standards, judging principles, and the evolution of HYROX as a professional sport.

Introduction

Some of the best ideas don't emerge from brainstorming sessions or whiteboards covered in Post-it notes. They come from a simple, almost nagging observation — the feeling that something obvious is missing, even though it should have existed long ago. That was the case with HYROX.

In 2017, Christian Toetzke and Moritz Fürste asked a question that anyone could have asked, but that apparently no one had yet said out loud: why is there no clear, standardised competition for the millions of ambitious fitness athletes out there? The sporting landscape had a defined summit for almost every discipline. Those who ran trained for the marathon. Those who sought endurance and versatility set their sights on the Ironman. CrossFit athletes measured themselves against one another in the Open. But the enormously growing world of functional training — those millions of people who pull weighted sleds, heave sandbags, and grind away on rowing ergometers every single day — had no equivalent. No finish line. No shared stage. Plenty of sweat, but no real destination.

The answer to this gap was HYROX: an indoor competition built on clarity and comparability. Eight kilometres of running, broken up into 8x 1km followed by eight functional workout stations — identical worldwide, the same for every single participant. No surprise formats, no arbitrarily assembled exercises, no element of luck. Whoever is better prepared is faster. As simple as that. As radical as that. And it genuinely was a provocation at the time, because the prevailing spirit of the functional fitness world was built on constant variation — on the unexpected as a governing principle. HYROX thought in precisely the opposite direction, trusting that comparability is not the enemy of sport, but its very foundation.

The first official event took place in Hamburg in 2018, but the concept was never intended as a one-off occasion. From the very beginning, it was designed as a series format — scalable, international, and accessible enough for spectators to follow.

1.1 Origins

The story of HYROX begins not with a revolutionary breakthrough, but with a gap — one of those gaps that, once you've seen it, becomes impossible to unsee. By the mid-2010s, functional fitness had become one of the fastest-growing movements in sport. Commercial gyms were filling up with sleds, ski ergs, and battle ropes. The training was serious, the commitment was real, and the athletes were hungry for more. The only thing missing was somewhere to actually compete.

Christian Toetzke and Moritz Fürste identified this gap in 2017 and asked the question that would change things: why shouldn't fitness athletes have a standardized race of their own? The answer they built was HYROX — and the first event took place in Hamburg in 2018. The core philosophy was deceptively simple. No randomness. No creative surprises. HYROX would be comparable — across events, across seasons, across continents. Sport before lifestyle, performance before branding, fairness through standardisation.

1.2 The HYROX Race Concept

If you had to explain HYROX to someone who had never heard of it, you could do so in two sentences. Eight kilometres of running, broken into eight segments of one kilometre each. Between every run, one functional workout station. That's it. No hidden elements, no surprise rounds, no format that changes from city to city.

This simplicity is, in itself, a design philosophy. HYROX is built on the principle that a great competition doesn't need mystery — it needs repeatability. The format is identical whether you're racing in Manchester,

Miami, or Munich. The workouts are the same, the distances are the same, the loads are the same. What changes is only the athlete.

The eight workout stations for able bodied divisions, completed in fixed order, test a deliberately broad range of physical qualities: cardiovascular endurance, muscular stamina, coordination, and mental resilience. A HYROX race doesn't reward a single specialist. It rewards the complete athlete.

#	Station	Distance / Volume	Primary Demand
1	SkiErg	1,000 m	Upper body · Cardio
2	Sled Push	50 m	Leg drive · Power
3	Sled Pull	50 m	Posterior chain · Grip
4	Burpee Broad Jump	80 m	Full body · Explosiveness
5	Rowing	1,000 m	Full body · Cardio
6	Farmer's Carry	200 m	Grip · Core · Posture
7	Sandbag Lunges	100 m	Quads · Glutes · Balance
8	Wall Balls	100 reps	Full body · Endurance

The indoor arena format was another deliberate choice. An outdoor race is at the mercy of terrain, weather, and geography. An indoor event, by contrast, is a controlled environment — consistent flooring, consistent distances, consistent conditions. This makes HYROX times genuinely comparable across events and seasons. For coaches, standardisation transforms training from guesswork into a science.

1.3 Movement Standards & Judging

Every competitive sport lives or dies by the consistency of its officiating. HYROX operates on exactly the same principle: movement standards are not bureaucratic obstacles. They are the guarantee that every result means the same thing, wherever in the world it was achieved.

Each station comes with clearly defined standards. The SkiErg handles must be pulled to hip height. The Sled Push must travel the full prescribed distance under the correct load. The Wall Balls must reach their target — 9 feet (2.75 m) for women, 10 feet (3.05 m) for men. Squat depth must break parallel on every single repetition. A rep that does not meet the standard is a no-rep, and a no-rep must be repeated. There are no shortcuts, no leniency for fatigue, and no negotiation mid-race.

The 2025/26 season brought a refined approach to penalties. The updated rulebook moved to a unified time-penalty system. For the Wall Balls specifically, each missing or invalid rep incurs a 15-second time penalty. For sled, burpee broad jump and sandbag stations, athletes receive one warning before a 15-second penalty is applied per subsequent infringement. The simplicity of this system is intentional — it is easier to enforce consistently, easier for athletes to understand, and harder to game.

Judges are trained to be neutral, objective, and educational. The best coaches teach movement standards not as rules to be memorised, but as qualities to be built into the body. An athlete who genuinely owns a proper Wall Ball isn't worried about the judge. They're thinking about their pace.

1.4 Behaviour & Integrity — The HYROX Code of Conduct

HYROX competitions rely not only on clear rules and movement standards, but also on mutual respect, integrity, and sportsmanship between athletes, judges, and officials. All participants are expected to compete honestly, respect officiating decisions, and follow race instructions; unsporting behaviour such as verbal abuse, obstruction of other athletes, or deliberate rule violations is not tolerated. In serious cases, breaches of the Code of Conduct may result in penalties or disqualification in order to protect the fairness and integrity of the sport.

1.5 Race Categories & Athlete Classes

One of HYROX's most important decisions was to build a category system broad enough to accommodate virtually everyone who trains seriously. The Open division is the entry point. The Pro division demands heavier loads and stricter movement standards. Doubles and Relay categories introduce a team dimension. Adaptive categories ensure that athletes with physical impairments are genuinely included in practice.

HYROX Race Divisions — Season 2025/26 (from source infographic):

Division	Description	Load
Open	Standard loads across all stations. The foundation of every HYROX event and the entry point for new athletes. Open to all registered participants — no qualification required.	Standard loads · All athletes
Pro	Increased loads and stricter movement standards. Designed for experienced competitors seeking a higher physical and technical challenge within the same race format.	Competitive · Heavy loads
Doubles	Two athletes share all eight workout stations equally. Available in Men, Women, and Mixed pairings. Loads correspond to Open division standards for each athlete's gender — except Mixed, which uses Men's Open weights.	Team of 2 · Open loads
Relay	A team of four splits the race: each member completes two 1 km runs and two workout stations. All four teammates reunite at the Wall Ball station to cross the finish line together.	Team of 4 · Open loads
Adaptive	Modified format for athletes with physical impairments. Exercises, loads, and distances are adapted to ensure full participation. HYROX is committed to inclusive racing at every level.	Inclusive · Modified

Within the Open and Pro divisions, athletes are further sorted by age group. This structure acknowledges something that recreational sport often ignores: a 52-year-old competing against a 24-year-old is not a fair contest, even if both are in exceptional shape. Age categories restore fairness and, crucially, extend the competitive lifespan of an athlete considerably. HYROX is not a sport you age out of — it is a sport you grow into.

HYROX Age Groups — Season 2025/26 (from source infographic):

Age Range	Category	Description
16–24	Youth	Entry into competitive HYROX · Development phase
25–29	Prime	Peak performance window · High competition density
30–39	Core	Experience and fitness converge · Largest category by entries
40–49	Veteran	Strength of experience · Full racing capability
50–59	Masters	Sustained performance · Fastest-growing demographic
60+	Grand Masters	HYROX for life · Proof that sport has no expiry date

1.6 Championships & The Professional Pathway

HYROX operates as a structured race series, which means that individual events are not isolated experiences but points within a larger competitive season. Local and national races form the base of the pyramid. Above them sit Continental Championships. At the apex is the HYROX World Championship, the annual gathering that determines the best HYROX athletes on the planet.

The Championship Pathway — Season 2025/26 (from source infographic):

Level	Name	Description	Key Facts
01	Open Race	Local and national events held across 95+ cities worldwide. Open to all registered athletes — no qualification required.	95+ events · All athletes · No qualification
02	Continental Championships	Regional Championships bringing together top athletes from each continent: Americas, EMEA, and APAC. Higher competitive stakes, stronger fields, and qualification significance.	3 regions · Qualification required
03	World Championship	The annual global final. Qualification is earned through season results — consistency rewarded over a single race.	Annual · Global final · Season qualification
04	Elite 15	The world's top 15 female and 15 male athletes. Invitation-only format run across four Major races (Hamburg, Melbourne, Phoenix, Warsaw) and three Regional Championships.	Invitation only · Top 15 per gender · 7 races/season

At the very top of this structure sits the Elite 15. For the 2025/26 season, the Elite 15 series consists of four Major races — Hamburg, Melbourne, Phoenix, and Warsaw — alongside three Regional Championship races in Washington DC, Copenhagen, and Brisbane. Each Major draws the fifteen fastest qualified women and fifteen fastest qualified men in the world, selected through a rolling 365-day qualification window based on verified Pro division times.

The qualification system rewards consistency rather than a single extraordinary performance. The athletes who reach the top are not those who had one inspired day. They are the ones who showed up, trained intelligently, competed with integrity, and improved over time.

HYROX Youngstars — Purpose, Design & Development

Pathway

HYROX Youngstars is not a scaled-down version of adult sport. It is a purposefully designed entry point into a lifelong fitness journey — one built on the principles of child development, long-term athlete development, and the belief that how a young person first experiences competitive movement will shape their relationship with exercise for decades.

2.1 Mission & Vision

The mission of HYROX Youngstars is straightforward: to provide every child between the ages of 8 and 15 with a safe, structured, and genuinely exciting first experience of fitness competition. The vision reaches further — to establish HYROX as the sport of choice for young people who want to test themselves physically, grow mentally, and belong to a community that values effort over outcome.

Four core values underpin every decision within the Youngstars programme. They are not aspirational statements printed on a wall; they are operational principles that shape course design, judge behaviour, athlete welfare protocols, and coaching standards.

Safety First

No competitive outcome justifies placing a young athlete at risk. Loads, distances, and movement standards have been calibrated against paediatric exercise science, not against what adult athletes can do. Growth-plate sensitivity, cardiovascular immaturity, and the psychological fragility of children in competitive environments are each taken seriously. Every station modification in the Youngstars format exists because of safety evidence, not coaching convenience.

Fun and Intrinsic Motivation

Children who enjoy an activity return to it. The Youngstars race experience is designed to generate positive emotional associations with effort: the atmosphere is celebratory, judges are encouragers as well as assessors, and the eight-station format produces natural variety that sustains engagement across the race. Programmes that prioritise elite performance at youth level routinely produce high dropout rates in adolescence. Youngstars is built on the opposite premise — that a child who leaves their first race smiling is worth infinitely more to the long-term health of sport than one who wins but burns out.

Skill Before Load

The Youngstars movement standards prioritise technique acquisition over weight lifted or distance covered. An 8-year-old performing a controlled bodyweight lunge is developing the neuromuscular patterning they will need to execute a loaded lunge safely at 14. By the time heavier loads arrive, the movement template is established.

Character Before Performance

HYROX Youngstars explicitly develops character alongside physical competence. Respect for competitors, discipline in preparation, resilience in difficulty, and a growth mindset towards failure are all embedded in the programme structure. These are not optional extras — they are assessed implicitly in how athletes and coaches engage with officials, with the course, and with each other. A Youngstars race is a laboratory for the attitudes that define a high-performing adult.

2.2 Age Groups and Developmental Windows

HYROX Youngstars operates across four age groups: 8–9 years, 10–11 years, 12–13 years, and 14–15 years. Each group corresponds to a recognised developmental window in childhood and early adolescence, during which different physical and psychological capacities emerge.

8–9 Years: The Fundamentals Window

Children in this age band are in the critical period for fundamental movement skill acquisition. Their nervous systems are exceptionally responsive to varied movement stimulation. Strength, speed, and endurance are all trainable, but none should be isolated or overloaded. The Youngstars format for this age group uses bodyweight movement, minimal external loads, and short, manageable distances. The social dimension of competition — learning to start, to follow the course, to finish, and to engage with the event process — is as important as any physical outcome.

10–11 Years: Building the Movement Library

The 10–11 window sees the continuation of fundamental skill development alongside the early emergence of sport-specific coordination. Children in this group can begin to absorb and retain more complex movement instructions, can self-monitor their technique with guidance, and show greater consistency in effort output. The coaching emphasis shifts towards deliberate practice — the purposeful refinement of movement quality rather than simple participation.

12–13 Years: Technique Consolidation

The 12–13 age group marks the first point at which HYROX introduces a meaningful distinction between Girls and Boys divisions. This reflects the differential impact of early puberty on strength, body composition, and cardiovascular capacity. Girls in this group often experience their peak height velocity earlier than Boys, which has direct implications for load prescription and injury risk. Boys in the same age band frequently demonstrate rapid strength gains, which must be channelled carefully to avoid technique deterioration.

The movement modifications that distinguished the younger groups begin to give way to more adult-adjacent standards: the Sled Pull replaces the Sled Drag, Wall Ball introduces a height target for the first time, and the run structure doubles.

14–15 Years: Bridging to Performance

Athletes in the 14–15 age group are approaching the physical maturity that allows them to engage with near-adult race structures. Their run format mirrors the full HYROX adult format — a lap between every station — while loads across all eight stations move significantly closer to the open divisions of the adult races. This is a deliberate bridge: athletes completing their final Youngstars season at 15 should feel a clear pathway ahead of them towards Open competition at 16.

It is also the age group where the psychological demands of competition most closely resemble adult experience. Coaches working with 14–15 athletes should be comfortable discussing performance anxiety, goal-setting, and the management of competitive identity.

2.3 Race Format

The Youngstars race format retains the essential DNA of a HYROX event — a sequence of running and functional fitness stations — while adapting the structure progressively across age groups to match developmental capacity. All four age groups complete the same eight workout stations; what differs is the distance and load at each station, the run volume between stations, and, in some cases, the specific movement variant performed.

Run Structure

Each lap in the Youngstars format is between 230 and 280 metres, consistent across all age groups:

- **8–9 years:** Athletes complete one entry lap before the first workout station, one lap after Frogger Jumps, and one lap after the Lunges with stations still completed consecutively between the run blocks. This structure delivers a genuine race experience while keeping total running volume appropriate for younger competitors.

- **10–11 years:** Athletes complete one entry lap before the first workout station, one lap after Burpee Broad Jumps, and one lap after the Lunges with stations still completed consecutively between the run blocks.
- **12–13 years:** Athletes complete two entry laps before the first station and two laps after the Lunges, with stations still completed consecutively between the run blocks. The increased run volume reflects the greater aerobic capacity of this age group.
- **14–15 years:** Athletes complete a full lap between every workout station — the identical structure to the adult HYROX format. This is the fullest expression of the HYROX race model and serves as a direct preparation for Open competition.

Station	8–9 yrs	10–11 yrs
SkiErg	300 m	400 m
Sled Push	15 m / 35 kg	15 m / 50 kg
Sled Method	DRAG (rope loop, facing sled)	DRAG (rope loop, facing sled)
Sled Load	15 m / 25 kg	15 m / 40 kg
Burpee / Frogger	Frogger 20 m	Burpee Broad Jump 20 m
Rowing	200 m	300 m
Farmer's Carry	2×4 kg / 50 m	2×6 kg / 50 m
Lunges	Bodyweight 20 m	Bodyweight 20 m
Wall Ball	1 kg / 50 reps (no target)	2 kg / 50 reps (no target)

Station	12–13 Girls	12–13 Boys	14–15 Girls	14–15 Boys
SkiErg	500 m	500 m	600 m	600 m
Sled Push	30 m / 60 kg	30 m / 70 kg	30 m / 70 kg	30 m / 102 kg
Sled Method	PULL	PULL	PULL	PULL
Sled Load	30 m / 25 kg	30 m / 50 kg	30 m / 50 kg	30 m / 78 kg
Burpee	Broad Jump 40 m	Broad Jump 40 m	Broad Jump 40 m	Broad Jump 40 m
Rowing	400 m	400 m	500 m	500 m
Farmer's Carry	2×8 kg / 100 m	2×12 kg / 100 m	2×12 kg / 100 m	2×16 kg / 100 m
Lunges	5 kg / 40 m	7.5 kg / 40 m	7.5 kg / 40 m	10 kg / 40 m
Wall Ball	2 kg / 2.4 m / 50 reps	3 kg / 2.4 m / 50 reps	3 kg / 2.4 m / 50 reps	4 kg / 2.7 m / 50 reps

Three Adaptation Principles

All modifications across the Youngstars age groups are governed by three principles:

- **Progressive overload matched to developmental stage:** Loads and distances increase systematically from age group to age group, but never at a rate that outpaces the capacity of a developing musculoskeletal, neural or cardiorespiratory system.
- **Movement variant before load variant:** Where a movement is inappropriate for a younger age group — such as a walking backwards Sled Pull for an 8-year-old — the modification uses a different movement pattern (the Sled Drag) rather than simply reducing the load on the adult pattern.
- **Technique-gated progression:** Athletes are not automatically promoted to higher-load variants simply because they age into the next group. Movement standards must be met. Judges at Youngstars events are trained to assess not only completion but quality, and the coaching programme emphasises

readiness over chronological entitlement.

2.4 Movement Standards and Safety

Movement standards in Youngstars serve a dual purpose: they ensure competitive fairness and, more critically, they protect young athletes from injury. Officials at Youngstars events are instructed to function as technique facilitators, not penalty enforcers. Their primary role is to keep young athletes moving safely and confidently through the course.

Growth-Sensitive Loading

Peak height velocity — the period of most rapid growth — typically occurs between ages 11 and 13 for girls and between 13 and 15 for boys, though individual variation is substantial. During periods of rapid bone growth, the growth plates are more vulnerable to compressive and shear loading. The HYROX Youngstars loading model deliberately avoids prescribing maximal or near-maximal loads for any age group, and coaches are trained to recognise the signs of growth-related discomfort that should prompt immediate modification or rest.

The Judge as Facilitator

Rather than standing at a station and issuing no-reps, the Youngstars judge is trained to provide brief, positive cues — "stand tall", "drive through your heels", "control the catch" — that help the athlete meet the standard without interrupting their flow. Penalties are applied only where safety is compromised or where repeated encouragement has failed to produce the required movement quality.

2.5 The CHAMPIONS Mindset

HYROX Youngstars is built on the belief that athletic development and character development are inseparable. The CHAMPIONS values — Courage, Humility, Attitude, Mindfulness, Persistence, Inclusion, Ownership, Networking (teamwork and connection), and Safety — define what it means to grow as both an athlete and a person.

Value	Description
Courage	Young athletes are encouraged to step into challenges with bravery, whether that means attempting a new movement standard, pushing through fatigue, or simply standing on the start line for the first time. Courage is not the absence of fear; it's the willingness to act despite it.
Humility	Humility keeps competition healthy. Athletes are expected to treat judges, peers, equipment, and the race environment with grounded respect. A humble athlete listens, learns, and acknowledges others' efforts. Officials and coaches model this same humility, ensuring that respect flows in every direction.
Attitude	A positive, constructive attitude is a performance skill. Maintaining focus across eight demanding stations requires more than physical preparation — it requires emotional steadiness. Athletes learn that their attitude shapes their experience, their effort, and the energy they bring to others on the course.
Mindfulness	Mindfulness is woven into both preparation and performance. Arriving equipped, warming up with intention, and understanding the race briefing all reflect mindful habits. On the course, mindfulness shows up in pacing, movement quality, and the ability to reset after a mistake.
Persistence	HYROX is hard! Youngstars athletes encounter discomfort, setbacks, and moments where quitting feels easier than continuing. Persistence is the capacity to keep going: to finish the last laps, to hold form on the final station, to try again after a no rep. These moments are not obstacles to the programme; they are the programme.

Value	Description
Inclusion	Every athlete deserves to feel they belong. Youngstars events are designed as learning environments where mistakes are normal and comparison is kept developmentally appropriate. Coaches frame challenges as opportunities, ensuring that every child, regardless of finish position or time, feels valued and supported.
Ownership	Ownership means taking responsibility for preparation, effort, and behaviour. Athletes learn to check their equipment, understand their stations, and manage their own warm up. After the race, ownership shows up in how they reflect on what went well and what they want to improve.
Networking (Teamwork & Connection)	Connection is a competitive advantage. Cheering for others, celebrating opponents, and supporting teammates builds a culture where everyone rises together. Youngstars athletes learn that teamwork doesn't end when the race starts, it continues through encouragement, shared effort, and genuine sportsmanship.
Safety	Safety underpins everything. Judges, coaches, and staff are trained to maintain a safe environment physically and emotionally. Athletes are taught proper technique, spatial awareness, and how to communicate if something feels wrong. A safe environment allows courage, growth, and performance to flourish.

2.6 Long-Term Athlete Development

An athlete who enters the Youngstars programme at age 8 and follows the full pathway has eight years of structured competitive development before they reach open HYROX competition:

- Two seasons in the 8–9 age group, establishing fundamental movement literacy and a positive relationship with competition
- Two seasons in the 10–11 group, consolidating technique and introducing modest progressive loading
- Two seasons in the 12–13 group, experiencing the competition format with the adult-adjacent Sled Pull and Wall Ball target
- Two seasons in the 14–15 group, competing in the full HYROX run structure and volume & loads approaching the adult Open divisions

The athlete who completes this journey at 15 is ready — physically, technically, and psychologically — to step into Open competition at 16 with a genuine competitive foundation. The athlete who does not go on to compete at Open level has still gained something of profound value: eight years of structured, progressive, joyful physical activity that will shape their relationship with movement for the rest of their life.

2.7 The Role of the Youngstars Coach

Coaching young athletes in a competitive fitness environment demands a skill set that extends well beyond technical knowledge of the eight HYROX stations. The Youngstars coach operates at the intersection of physical education, child psychology, athlete development, and talent pathway management.

Technical Competency

The Youngstars coach must have a thorough command of the movement standards for all four age groups, including the critical distinctions between variants: Drag vs. Pull, squat throw vs. target throw, Frogger vs. Burpee Broad Jump.

Child Development Knowledge

Understanding the developmental windows outlined in Section 2.2 is not optional for a Youngstars coach — it is foundational. A coach who prescribes adult training volumes for a 9-year-old, or who responds to a 13-year-old's technique breakdown during a growth spurt with additional loading, is working against the evidence base. Youngstars coaches are expected to be familiar with the principles of LTAD, to understand

peak height velocity and its implications for training load, and to be capable of modifying session content in response to individual developmental variation.

Mental and Emotional Coaching

Children experience competition very differently from adults. Pre-race anxiety, post-result disappointment, social comparison, and fear of public failure are all normal experiences for young competitors that can, if handled poorly, produce lasting aversion to sport. The Youngstars coach is trained to normalise these experiences, to provide perspective without dismissiveness, and to use competition outcomes — whatever they are — as coaching material.

Talent Pathway Guidance

For athletes who demonstrate exceptional ability or motivation, the Youngstars coach plays an important role in pathway guidance. This includes understanding when an athlete is ready to progress from Youngstars to Open competition, how to communicate that transition to the athlete and their family, and what training adjustments are required to support it. It also includes the wisdom to recognise when a highly performing young athlete needs to continue enjoying the Youngstars environment rather than being accelerated prematurely into higher-pressure formats.

HYROX Academy Coaching Standards

Every profession that takes itself seriously eventually does the same thing: it writes down what good looks like. Not to create bureaucracy, but to create clarity — a shared language for what coaches should know, how they should behave, and what athletes can legitimately expect when they walk into a HYROX Training Club anywhere in the world.

The standards are not a checklist to be completed once and filed away. They are a living framework for reflection — a mirror you can hold up against your own practice, at any stage of your coaching career, to understand where you are performing well and where honest development work remains to be done.

Four Core Values

- **Holistic athlete development** means that a HYROX coach is not just developing an athlete's physical capacity. They are developing the whole person — including their mental resilience, their relationship with sport, their sense of belonging in a training community, and their long-term relationship with their own health and fitness.
- **High performance** means that standards are not calibrated to the minimum acceptable. The HYROX Coaching Standards describe what excellent looks like — at every level.
- **Athlete well-being** means that the long-term interests of the athletes in a coach's care always take precedence over short-term performance outcomes, programme convenience, or commercial pressure.
- **Continuous development** means that the standards apply to the coach as much as to the athlete. A HYROX coach is expected to be an ongoing learner — not only completing required continuing education units, but actively seeking feedback, reflecting on their practice, and maintaining intellectual humility about the limits of what they know.

These standards are universal — they apply whether a coach is working with a ten-year-old in a Youngstars class, a masters athlete preparing for their fifth HYROX race, or an elite competitor targeting a podium at the World Championships.

The Six Coaching Standards

Standard	Core Focus	Youngstars Example
1 – Set Clear Expectations & Build Culture	Environment, values, growth mindset	Opening every session with a brief acknowledgement of expected effort levels and inclusive language
2 – Support Athlete Development & Progression	Structured progression, LTAD, inclusion	Designing a 4-week programming block that progressively builds interval intensity for a mixed ability youth group
3 – Apply HYROX Expertise & Coaching Skill	Knowledge, communication, adaptability	Explaining the connection between compromised running and sled push technique in accessible terms
4 – Plan & Deliver High-Quality Sessions	Session design, safety, time management	Arriving early to set up stations, running a structured warm up, and finishing on time with a cool down and reflection
5 – Assess, Feedback & Adapt	Assessment, feedback, adaptation	Using RPE check-ins mid-session and adjusting interval intensity in response to the group's reported effort
6 – Lead with Integrity & Collaboration	Ethics, wellbeing, collaboration	Referring a youth athlete with persistent knee pain to a physiotherapist rather than continuing to programme

Standard 1 – Set Clear Expectations & Build Culture

This is the standard that shapes every participant's first impression and last memory of a session. Culture is not created by accident — it is built deliberately, through the consistent application of values and expectations over time. A HYROX Youngstars coach who establishes clear behavioural norms, celebrates effort alongside achievement, and creates an atmosphere of respect and belonging is building a culture that makes people want to return. This standard also encompasses the growth mindset principle: athletes should be supported in seeing setbacks, bad sessions, and race disappointments as information and opportunity rather than judgment.

Standard 2 – Support Athlete Development & Progression

Structured, progressive coaching is the engine of long-term athletic development. This standard requires coaches to move beyond delivering pre-designed workouts and engage with the developmental trajectory of each athlete — or, in a group context, each cohort of athletes — with purpose and knowledge. It encompasses the full spectrum of HYROX populations: youth athletes, masters athletes, female athletes, and adapted athletes.

Standard 3 – Apply HYROX Expertise & Coaching Skill

Knowledge without the ability to communicate it effectively is not enough. This standard requires coaches to demonstrate both deep understanding of HYROX-specific demands and the pedagogical skill to translate that knowledge into coaching that participants can absorb and act on. It includes movement standards, biomechanics, race strategy, and the psychological dimensions of performance.

Standard 4 – Plan & Deliver High-Quality Sessions

Session quality begins in preparation and is realised in delivery. This standard covers the full arc of a coaching session — from warm-up through technical development, conditioning, and reflection — and requires that every component is purposeful, structured, and connected to the athlete's development goals. Crucially, it also requires adaptability: the ability to adjust a session in real time when the group's needs, energy, or circumstances diverge from what was planned.

Standard 5 – Assess, Feedback & Adapt

This standard closes the coaching loop. Assessment without feedback is just data collection. Feedback without adaptation is just commentary. This standard requires coaches to use a range of assessment tools and to act on what they learn. Constructive, actionable feedback tailored to the individual or group is the mechanism through which athletes develop self-awareness and coaches demonstrate their commitment to ongoing improvement.

Standard 6 – Lead with Integrity & Collaboration

The final standard addresses the character of the coach rather than the competence. Integrity in coaching means ethical, consistent, and respectful behaviour in all settings — even, and especially, when no one is watching. Collaboration means working as part of a broader support ecosystem rather than operating as an isolated authority. Prioritising long-term athlete welfare over short-term performance outcomes is the clearest expression of this standard in practice.

Quality Assurance Observation Rubric

Rating	Standard 1: Set Clear Expectations & Build Culture	Standard 5: Assess, Feedback & Adapt
5 – Exemplary	Consistently creates an inspiring, inclusive environment where athletes are visibly motivated, respectful, and invested in each other's progress. Growth mindset language is natural and embedded.	Uses multiple assessment methods fluidly, provides specific and timely feedback to individuals and the group, and adjusts programming mid-session with clear rationale. Athletes demonstrate self-awareness.
4 – Proficient	Positive culture is clearly established; expectations are communicated well at the start and reinforced during the session. Minor inconsistencies in how different participants are engaged.	Assessment tools are used effectively; feedback is constructive and mostly specific. Occasional missed opportunities to adapt intensity or scaling based on observed data.
3 – Satisfactory	A broadly positive atmosphere is present but is not actively built or reinforced by the coach. Expectations are stated once but not revisited or demonstrated.	Basic assessment (e.g. RPE check-in) is completed; feedback is generally positive but lacks specificity. Adaptation to session is limited to obvious signals rather than proactive adjustment.
2 – Needs Improvement	Culture feels inconsistent — some participants are engaged but others are peripheral or unclear on expectations. Negative or dismissive language used in at least one instance.	Assessment is minimal or inconsistent; feedback is generic or absent for most participants. Session continues unchanged despite visible signs of mismatch between planned and actual needs.
1 – Below Standard	No clear expectations established; atmosphere is disorganised or exclusionary. Coach appears unaware of the group's engagement or behaviour.	No evident assessment practice; feedback is absent, incorrect, or counterproductive. Session is delivered rigidly regardless of participant experience.

A score of 3 on any standard is not a failure — it is an accurate starting point for development. Coaches who use the rubric honestly and regularly develop a clear and actionable picture of their coaching profile. The most important number on the rubric is not the current score — it is the direction of travel across multiple assessments.

Safeguarding in HYROX Youngstars

At HYROX, safeguarding underpins everything we do. Our commitment is built on three core principles:

- The welfare of participants is paramount.
- Everyone has the right to safety, and to prevention and protection from harm.
- All concerns and incidents will be taken seriously and responded to appropriately.

Children are defined as young persons under 18 years of age and are protected under the United Nations Convention on the Rights of the Child which has been ratified by 195 countries, making it the most widely ratified human rights treaty in the World.

What is Wellbeing — The Person

Wellbeing includes the physical, emotional, social, and psychological aspects of an individual's health and quality of life. It is the holistic support provided to participants to promote their overall health, happiness, and fulfilment. By prioritising the wellbeing of children, we can create an inclusive and supportive environment that fosters personal growth, positive relationships, and a sense of belonging for all individuals involved in sports activities.

At Youngstars this means: Children feel safe · Children feel valued · Children feel respected and included · Children enjoy participation and a sense of belonging. When we prioritise wellbeing, we create environments where children can thrive — not just compete.

What is Welfare — The Environment

When we refer to welfare, we mean the overall physical and mental wellbeing of everyone involved in sport. Creating a positive and inclusive environment where individuals feel happy, confident, and valued — not just judged on their performance. It involves a proactive ongoing duty of care to ensure that all young participants are safe, respected, healthy, and fully supported throughout their sporting experience.

Coaches have a duty of care to provide a safe, supportive environment. This includes: Safe equipment · Appropriate session planning · Positive and Inclusive culture · Clear behavioural expectations · Age appropriate training · Safe supervision

What is Safeguarding — The Processes and Procedures

Safeguarding means the measures, systems and procedures we undertake to protect the health, wellbeing and human rights of individuals and to create an environment where all individuals can be involved in sports activities free from the threat of harm. These measures allow people to live free from abuse, harm and neglect. Safeguarding in sport is particularly important given the inherent physical nature of sport, combined with the imbalance of power between sports personnel and child participants.

This is particularly important in: Physically hands on coaching · 1:1 technical correction · Competitive environments · Situations with power imbalance

Types of Abuse

Type	Definition	Specific Situations to Watch For
1. Physical Abuse	Physical abuse is when someone intentionally or knowingly uses force or contact against another person in a way that is unwanted or harmful. This includes direct contact (hitting, pushing) and non-contact actions that cause harm or pain.	A child is pushed or shoved during training · Parents/guardians forcing children to continue despite injury · Criticism or negative remarks about a child's body · Injuries such as cuts, bruises, harming marks · Conflicting, unconvincing, or no explanation for the child's injury · Using excessive physical force · Uses harsh physical discipline
2. Sexual Abuse	Sexual abuse includes any sexual activity — contact or non-contact — that happens without consent or understanding. In sports, physical contact such as coaching, physiotherapy, or medical checks can be legitimate, but may be misused as a pretext for abuse.	Any child being touched inappropriately · Use of massage or medical examination as a cover for sexual contact · Inappropriate sexualised comments or gestures · Being secretive and isolated · Taking unsolicited photos · Grooming behaviour · Suddenly refuses to change for gym · Reports nightmares · Displays unusual sexual knowledge or behaviour
3. Psychological/ Emotional Abuse	Psychological abuse is behaviour intended to cause emotional or mental harm.	Yelling, belittling, or humiliating children · Threatening language or intimidation during training · Excessive criticism intended to shame a child · Pressuring children to perform beyond ability · Constantly blaming, belittling, or berating · To overtly reject or dismiss an individual · To give individuals the silent treatment
4. Neglect	Neglect is the failure to meet a child's essential needs, either deliberately or through lack of understanding. This includes withholding food, water, warmth, shelter, or medical care.	Allowing a child to participate while sick or injured · Failing to provide sufficient hydration, food, or rest · Ignoring signs of exhaustion or distress · Children left unsupervised · Inadequate clothing for conditions · Not following medical guidance
5. Bullying	Bullying is behaviour that causes someone to feel hurt, threatened, frightened, or left out. It can happen face-to-face or online.	A child repeatedly insulting, mocking, or excluding another · Anyone shouting at children to intimidate or control them · Public humiliation of a child · Filming with a clear negative intention · Racial taunts, graffiti, gestures · Homophobic taunts, abusive comments
6. Harassment	Harassment is unwanted conduct that violates dignity or creates an intimidating, hostile, degrading, humiliating, or offensive environment. Often based on personal characteristics such as race, gender, appearance, sexual orientation, religion, or disability.	Based on personal characteristics including race, gender, appearance, sexual orientation, religion, or disability

Type	Definition	Specific Situations to Watch For
7. Grooming	Grooming refers to an individual working to create an emotional connection with a child to gain their trust with the distinct purpose of sexual abuse or exploitation. Grooming can be undertaken by both males and females and can occur both online and in the real world.	Offering advice and understanding · Buying gifts, such as equipment · Giving the child extra attention · Using professional position or reputation · Taking them on trips, outings, or holidays · Isolating child from friends or family · Introducing secrets to control or frighten the victim · Blackmail to stop them from telling anyone about the abuse
8. Trafficking	Human trafficking is the process of recruiting, moving, or transporting persons to exploit them, whether through forced work or their sale. They are often moved away from their homes and forced to work in the sex trade.	It is important for individuals involved in sports to be aware of the signs of human trafficking and to know how to report it if they suspect that it is occurring

Who Might Abuse and What to Look Out For

Abuse can be perpetrated by both strangers and people we know. It can occur in any type of relationship, including between family members and in community and sports settings. It is more common for abuse to be perpetrated by someone the victim knows, such as a family member or a trusted adult.

People who sit in positions of power or trust can misuse their power or trust to abuse children. Abuse can occur between: Coach/teacher/instructor and child · Sport personnel and child (physios, psychologists) · Peer and peer

Peer-on-Peer Abuse

Peer-on-peer abuse is the physical, sexual, emotional and financial abuse and coercive control exercised within a child or young person's relationships, including intimate relations, friendships and wider peer associations. Peer on peer abuse is common in sporting contexts and needs to be addressed through safeguarding measures including codes of conduct. It includes: on and offline bullying · grooming children for sexual and criminal exploitation and trafficking · Being blackmailed to engage in sexual activities · Being threatened in changing rooms or toilets · Having sexual images taken of them without their consent · Being excluded from social groups · Having rumours and gossip spread about them.

Signs of Concerning Behaviour from Staff

- Insisting on physical affection such as hugging, tickling, etc.
- Refusing to allow a child privacy or to make their own decisions about personal matters
- Being overly interested in the sexual development of a child
- Insisting on time alone with a child with no interruptions
- Favouritism, making a particular child feel "special" compared with others
- Picking on a particular child, talking about them negatively with the rest of the training group
- Discussing or sharing sexual jokes or materials with a child online or offline
- Paying for things like physio or massage for children, buying expensive gifts or giving money

Signs of Distress in Children

Behaviour changes: Becoming withdrawn or very clingy · Suddenly having nightmares or other sleeping problems · Regressing to younger behaviours · Unaccountable fear of particular places or people · Personality changes or suddenly seems insecure · Outbursts of anger, being very defensive · Changes in

eating habits · Becoming secretive · Having unexplained gifts · An increased risk of violent behaviour · Antisocial behaviour · Involvement in crime at any age · Substance use · Inappropriate sexual exploration / language for their age and development

Emotional/Psychological Changes: Low self-esteem · Depression · Anxiety · Anorexia nervosa or disordered eating · Poor body image · Mistrust of others · Poor peer relationships · Difficulty regulating emotions · Self-harming / Suicide ideation · Shows extremes in behaviour · Is delayed in physical or emotional development

No single sign proves abuse — but patterns matter.

Creating Safe Spaces

Child-First Coaching

Child-first coaching is putting the child at the centre and prioritising their rights underpinned by the UN Convention on the rights of the child. The United Nations Convention on the Rights of the Child is a global agreement protecting the rights of every child under 18. It is built on four core principles: Non-Discrimination (Article 2) · Best Interests of the Child (Article 3) · Right to life, survival and development (Article 6) · Right to be heard (Article 12). And in addition Article 31 — The right to play.

A rights-based environment: Encourages participation and voice · Focuses on long term development · Promotes inclusion · Avoids win at all costs culture · Has clear codes of conducts · Risk assessments · Supervision ratios · Clear reporting procedures

The Rule of Two

The "rule of two" in safeguarding in sport refers to the requirement that at least two trusted adults should be present when working with children. The rule of two is often implemented in sport organisations as a best practice for safeguarding children. It is important to note that the "rule of two" is not a substitute for proper training and vigilance, and it should be used in conjunction with other safeguards and policies to protect children.

Coaches/Instructors/teachers should never coach in settings where they are on their own and unseen by others. Training should be conducted in the open with other children and coaches present or other adults such as parents/carers, or family members. Everyone working in spaces with children including medical staff should avoid being alone with a child.

Good Coaching Practice

Coaches play a crucial role in safeguarding children in sports. They hold positions of influence and trust, not just in participants, but also with parents, carers, and other family members. As so many place their trust in coaches, they don't just have a legal responsibility to keep children safe. They have a moral responsibility too. Regardless of the child's age, a coach can foster a culture of care and open communication to help prevent harm.

How coaches contribute to safeguarding and wellbeing: Role Models · Close relationships — insights into child participants' lives inside and outside of sport · First responders — coaches may spot the signs of abuse or neglect long before anyone else · Duty of Care — coaches have a legal duty of care to prioritise their child participants' safety and to report any concerns · Empowerment — a good coach can foster a safe and supportive environment that can empower children to speak up

Poor Practice

Poor practice includes: Favouritism · Isolation · Overtraining · Blurred boundaries · Ignoring distress signals · Dependence on coach for selection · Pressure to train through injury · Body image pressures in gym environments · Social media contact boundaries · Avoid 1-1 unsupervised situations where possible · Avoid personal messaging outside of official channels · Never share inappropriate content

The 4 R's Framework — How to Respond to Suspected or Reported Abuse

Step	Action	Key Points
Recognise	Safeguarding is everyone's responsibility. The safeguarding team cannot be everywhere, so you are the eyes and ears on the ground. Sometimes, you may notice something that doesn't feel right — maybe the behaviour of a spectator, a staff member, a parent/guardian, or another child.	If something seems off, report it to your Safeguarding Lead. Nothing is too small — your observation could be the missing piece that helps protect a child. You are not responsible for deciding if abuse or harm has occurred. Your role is to notice and report.
Respond	Once you have recognised a concern or received a disclosure, you must respond appropriately.	Steps to take: Ensure the child or person's safety · Provide calm reassurance · Listen carefully. Do NOT: Confront or contact the alleged abuser · Promise to keep secrets · Make assumptions or judgments · Delay reporting
Report	Report to Safeguarding Lead immediately.	Follow your organisational policy and procedures. Do not delay.
Record	Write factual information after reporting.	Use the child's own words where possible · Record date/time · Do not include opinion or interpretation

Never promise confidentiality to a child disclosing abuse. Explain calmly that you cannot promise secrecy but will share only with people who can help keep them safe.

Safeguarding Scenarios

Scenario 1 – The "Dedicated" Athlete

A 13-year-old, Mia, has been training intensely for an upcoming competition. You notice she looks exhausted and has mentioned feeling dizzy. Her parents insist she continues training, saying, "Champions push through pain." Mia looks uncomfortable but says nothing. **Correct action:** Stop the session, prioritise Mia's health, and report concerns if necessary. The coach has a duty of care that overrides performance pressure. Welfare and safety must come first.

Scenario 2 – Favouritism and Isolation

A coach regularly gives one child, Sam (14), extra 1:1 sessions in a closed gym space. The coach buys Sam new training gear and often says Sam is "different from the others." **Safeguarding concern:** Potential grooming behaviour and power imbalance. Isolation, gift-giving, secrecy, and favouritism are grooming red flags.

Scenario 3 – Sudden Behaviour Change

A normally confident 12-year-old, Leo, has become withdrawn, avoids changing rooms, and startles when adults approach. He has recently started wearing long sleeves during training. **Correct action:** Gently check in using open, supportive language and report concerns. Recognise patterns → Respond calmly → Report concerns. Do not investigate or ignore.

Scenario 4 – Emotional "Motivation"

During training, a coach shouts: "If you can't handle this, you don't belong here." One child becomes visibly upset but continues training. **Assessment:** Potential emotional abuse. Humiliation and shaming language can constitute emotional abuse, particularly when it impacts confidence or wellbeing.

Scenario 5 – Disclosure with a Condition

A child says quietly: "Something happened... but you can't tell anyone." **Correct response:** Explain you cannot promise secrecy but will share only with people who can help keep them safe. Never promise confidentiality. Be honest, calm, and child-centred.

Scenario 6 – Peer-on-Peer Abuse

You overhear older children threatening a younger child in the changing room, saying they must send embarrassing photos or they'll be excluded from the team. **Type:** Peer-on-peer abuse including coercion, bullying, and potentially sexual exploitation.

Scenario 7 – Unnecessary Physical Affection

You notice a staff member insists on hugging children after every session. Some children look uncomfortable but comply. **Correct action:** Raise the concern with the Safeguarding Lead. Report concerns appropriately — do not publicly accuse the staff member.

Scenario 8 – Uncertainty

You feel uneasy about how a parent speaks to their child — harsh criticism, constant body comments — but there is no clear evidence of abuse. **Correct action:** Document observations and report concerns. You do not need proof. Patterns and instincts matter. Record and report.

Evidence-Based Principles — LTAD, YPDM & TGfU

At the heart of HYROX YOUNGSTARS is a commitment to evidence-informed coaching. Our programme is not built on trends or assumptions, but on combining experiential expertise with well-established scientific models that explain how children grow, learn, and develop. Three key frameworks underpin our approach: Long-Term Athlete Development (LTAD), the Youth Physical Development Model (YPDM), and Teaching Games for Understanding (TGfU). Each contributes a vital piece of the YOUNGSTARS puzzle. Together, they ensure that every child's experience is developmentally appropriate, engaging, and effective, while building strong foundations for lifelong participation in physical activity.

Long-Term Athlete Development (LTAD)

The Long-Term Athlete Development model provides a structured roadmap for guiding children through sport and physical activity. Its central principle is simple but critical: children are not miniature adults. Their bodies, minds, and emotions are still developing, and they require training that reflects their stage of growth rather than adult performance expectations. LTAD outlines progressive stages, each with its own priorities. In the early "FUNDamentals" stage, the focus is not on competition or performance, but on developing fundamental movement skills that underpin all future athletic activity. Just as children must learn the alphabet before writing sentences, they must develop these movement foundations before specialising in more complex or demanding tasks.

Within HYROX YOUNGSTARS, this principle is reflected in how activities are delivered. HYROX stations are adapted into fun, engaging, and play-based challenges. For example, instead of emphasising high repetition load, younger children may complete obstacle-style movement circuits, relay games, or creative challenges that develop movement variety.

Only when children reach the later stages of adolescence should the emphasis be to introduce a child towards training to compete and win at competition. Another key benefit of LTAD is its emphasis on avoiding early specialisation. Research shows that children who specialise too early in a single sport are more likely to experience overuse injuries, burnout, and stagnation of potential. In contrast, children who experience a gradually progressive broad range of activities and environments develop more complete athletic skills and are more likely to remain active throughout their lives.

However, LTAD does have limitations. One of the most significant is its reliance on chronological age to define stages. In reality, children mature and acquire skills at different rates. Two children of the same age may differ greatly in height, maturation phase, emotional readiness, and sport specific application. This is why the Youth Physical Development Model is essential in complementing LTAD.

Stage	Approx. Age	Phase	Primary Focus
Active Start	Boys 0–6 / Girls 0–6	Physical Literacy	Fundamental Movement Skills
FUNDamentals	Boys 6–9 / Girls 6–8	Physical Literacy	Fundamental Movement Skills
Learning to Train	Boys 9–12 / Girls 8–11	Physical Literacy	Fundamental Sport Skills
Training to Train	Males 12–16 / Females 11–15	Building Physical & Mental Capability	Building Physical & Mental Capability
Learning to Compete	Males 16–20 / Females 15–19	Active for Life	High Performance Sport
Training to Compete	Males 20–23 / Females 19–23	Active for Life	High Performance Sport
Training to Win	Males 23+ / Females 23+	Active for Life	High Performance Sport

Youth Physical Development Model (YPDM)

The Youth Physical Development Model was developed to provide a more flexible and individualised framework for youth training. While LTAD provides the structure, YPDM provides the detail needed to adapt training to each child. A key concept within YPDM is that evidenced based gender based physical maturation phases is recognised as an integral pillar towards what physical components of fitness are emphasized. For example, a child experiencing a rapid growth spurt during adolescence, known as peak height velocity (PHV), will require a different set of physical components of fitness to concentrate on compared to a child in early to mid childhood (pre-PHV). At the same time, emotional and social factors may also influence their motivation and confidence.

The YPDM encourages coaches to recognise and respond to these differences. This is particularly relevant in mixed groups, where early and late developers train together. Rather than expecting uniform performance, coaches adapt tasks to provide appropriate challenges for everyone. In HYROX YOUNGSTARS, this means scaling exercises, adjusting fitness components, and focusing on movement range & quality rather than performance.

Phase	Age (approx.)	PHV Status	Physical Qualities Emphasised	Training Structure
Early Childhood	2–6	Pre-PHV	FMS, Mobility	Unstructured
Middle Childhood	6–11	Pre-PHV	FMS, SSS, Mobility, Agility, Speed	Low structure
Adolescence (pre/at PHV)	11–15 girls / 12–16 boys	PHV	SSS, Agility, Speed, Power, Strength	Moderate structure
Adolescence (post-PHV)	15–18	Post-PHV	Speed, Power, Strength, Hypertrophy, Endurance & MC	High structure
Adulthood	18+	Post-PHV	All qualities; sport-specific	Very high structure

FMS = fundamental movement skills · SSS = sport-specific skills · MC = metabolic conditioning · PHV = peak height velocity

Teaching Games for Understanding (TGfU)

While LTAD and YPDM focus on what children should develop and when, the pedagogical approaches must be considered. Pedagogy refers to the method and practice of teaching. Within HYROX YOUNGSTARS, pedagogy is not simply about delivering exercise sessions with sets, repetitions, rounds and rest time. It is about how coaches create learning environments that develop confident, competent, and motivated young movers.

The Teaching Games for Understanding (TGfU) model was created in response to traditional coaching methods that prioritised repetitive drills before allowing children to play. This technique-first approach often disengaged children. Many struggled to understand why they were performing certain drills, and as a result, motivation and enjoyment were reduced. The alternative: learning through games that had lasting impact on young people.

Several core principles emerged from this work:

- **Game-Centred Learning:** Games are the central learning vehicle · Skills are contextual, not isolated
- **Tactical Problems Drive Learning:** Sessions are built around "problems" · Encourages thinking and problem-solving
- **Modified Games:** Use of smaller teams, adjusted space, simplified rules · Allows all learners to participate meaningfully
- **Questioning:** Teachers guide learning using open-ended questions · Encourages reflection and understanding

TGfU uses modified games and challenges as the primary learning tool. Skills are developed within meaningful contexts, allowing children to understand not only how to perform a movement, but why and when to use it. Coaches guide learning through questioning and discussion which encourages children to reflect and think for themselves.

TGfU also uses modified tasks to ensure inclusion and success. Adjusting space, equipment, or rules allows all children to participate meaningfully, regardless of ability level. This supports confidence, enjoyment, and skill development simultaneously. This approach develops not only physical competence but also decision-making, creativity, and problem-solving — skills that are transferable across sport, education, and everyday life.

Fundamental Movement Skills

Fundamental Movement Skills (FMS) form the backbone of physical literacy. They are the essential building blocks that allow children to move confidently, explore their environment, and eventually thrive in sport and physical activity. Whether a child grows into a recreational mover or a competitive athlete, these skills shape their coordination, confidence, and long-term athletic development.

Children who do not develop fundamental movement skills often struggle with confidence, coordination, and physical competence as they grow. Without a solid movement foundation, everyday activities (running, jumping, catching, balancing) feel harder, which can lead to frustration and avoidance of physical play. Long term, poor FMS can contribute to lower physical literacy, reduced motivation to be active, and a higher likelihood of injury or inactivity in adolescence and adulthood.

At their core, FMS fall into three broad categories:

Category	Definition	Skills
Locomotor Skills	Skills that move the body from one place to another	Running · Jumping (two-foot take-off and landing) · Hopping (single-leg) · Skipping · Galloping · Sliding (sideways) · Leaping (one foot to the other)
Object Control Skills	Skills that involve manipulating or controlling an object	Throwing · Catching · Kicking · Striking (hand or implement) · Dribbling (hands or feet) · Rolling
Stability & Balance Skills	Skills that control the body in space	Balancing (static & dynamic) · Landing (absorbing force) · Twisting · Turning · Bending & stretching · Dodging · Stopping (deceleration)

These skills are not just for sport, they underpin everything from playground confidence to injury resilience. A child who develops a broad base of movement competence is far more likely to stay active, enjoy sport, and adapt to the increasingly complex demands of activities like HYROX.

FMS Progression Across Development Stages

Stage	Age	LTAD Phase	Focus	Coaching Approach
1. Early Stage	~2–6	Active Start	Exploration, play, variability	Play with movement; minimal instruction
2. Foundation Stage	~6–9	FUNDamentals	Refining FMS; intro to simple games	Add rules, targets, constrained space
3. Development Stage	~9–12	Learn to Train	Running → pacing; jumping → reactive strength; sequencing; dynamic balance	Representative learning design; decision-making
4. Specialisation Stage	~12–16 +	Train to Train	Linking skills into sport patterns; coordination under fatigue; refine under pressure	Blend physical + technical + cognitive demands
5. Performance Stage	16+	Train to Compete/Win	Efficiency, consistency, race execution	Marginal gains; individualisation

The pathway is not linear, but it is progressive: Fundamental Movement Skills → Movement Combinations → Adaptive Skills → Sport-Specific Performance → Mastery Under Pressure

Children who develop strong FMS early on: Learn new skills faster · Are more confident in physical environments · Are less likely to drop out of sport · Are more resilient to injury · Adapt better to complex or chaotic tasks. FMS are not something athletes complete, they are something they continually refine.

Social Emotional Learning & Behavioural Change

Coaching children and adolescents is one of the most rewarding things you can do in sport. You get to watch young people discover what they're capable of, build confidence in real time, and develop friendships that often last for years. But it can also be genuinely challenging. Young people arrive at your sessions carrying far more than their kit bags: friendship drama, school stress, family pressure, and emotions they haven't yet learned to name, let alone manage.

That "something else" has a name. It's Social Emotional Learning — SEL — and understanding it might be one of the most important things you do as a gym coach. Because what happens between the ears, and between people, determines far more about long-term athletic engagement than any training programme ever could.

What is SEL?

Social Emotional Learning is the process through which both children and adults develop the skills, knowledge, and attitudes needed to build a strong sense of who they are, manage their emotions effectively, and work toward their own goals as well as shared ones. SEL isn't a soft add-on to the "real" work of coaching. It is the real work. Research consistently shows that young people who develop strong SEL competencies perform better, build healthier relationships, make smarter decisions under pressure, and are significantly less likely to disengage from physical activity over time.

The five core competencies of SEL are:

- **Self-Awareness** — the ability to recognise and understand one's own emotions, values, and strengths
- **Self-Management** — regulating emotions, controlling impulses, and managing stress
- **Social Awareness** — understanding others' perspectives and showing empathy
- **Relationship Skills** — communicating effectively, collaborating, and resolving conflict
- **Responsible Decision-Making** — making ethical, constructive choices about personal and social behaviour

Behavior Is a Language

Behavior is how individuals respond to different situations through their actions, thoughts, and emotions. Behavior is never random. It is shaped by personality, past experiences, emotional state, culture, and the social norms of the group a child belongs to. When a young person acts out in your session, they are communicating something. The question isn't "why are they being difficult?" The better question is: "what are they telling me right now?"

How SEL Drives Behavioral Change

- **Self-Awareness** → **Better Decision-Making**: A child who can recognise what they're feeling is already better equipped to do something constructive with that feeling. Without self-awareness, emotion drives behavior automatically. With it, there's a gap — a brief but crucial space between feeling and action where good decisions live.
- **Self-Management** → **Emotional Control**: The ability to regulate impulse and manage stress shows up in your gym as a young athlete taking a breath after a failed attempt instead of giving up, or staying engaged in a team drill even when tired and frustrated.
- **Social Awareness** → **Empathy and Respect**: Can a child recognise that their teammate is struggling even if their face doesn't show it? This competency is the foundation of team cohesion.
- **Relationship Skills** → **Stronger Connections**: A team that can communicate during a workout, support each other through failure, and resolve disagreements constructively is a team that performs — and stays together.
- **Responsible Decision-Making** → **Lasting Positive Behavior**: When a young person can pause and ask "what will happen if I do this?" before acting, they are operating at a level of maturity that most coaches work toward.

Understanding the Ecology of Development

The Socio-Ecological Model describes five nested levels of influence shaping every young athlete:

- **Individual** — their physical abilities, psychology, motivation, and self-belief
- **Interpersonal** — direct relationships with coaches, teammates, parents, and teachers
- **Organisational** — the clubs, schools, and gyms they participate in, and the connections between them
- **Community** — local sports culture, facility access, neighbourhood safety, and funding priorities
- **Societal** — cultural values, gender norms, national policy, and media representations of sport

Sustainable development — behavioral change that actually sticks — requires addressing obstacles across multiple levels, not just focusing on the individual child.

Behavioral Change Is Not a Switch

The Transtheoretical Model (TTM) describes how people move through distinct stages of behavioral change:

- **Precontemplation** — No awareness or intention to change
- **Contemplation** — Aware that a change may be needed
- **Preparation** — Planning and committed to making a change
- **Action** — Implementing the intended behavioral changes
- **Maintenance** — Sustaining the change and preventing relapse

The critical insight here is that this process is not linear, and setbacks are a normal part of it. A child who regularly loses their temper in training is not broken — they may simply not yet have reached the contemplation stage. You can't shortcut the process by telling someone to change before they're ready. What you can do is design the environment and relationships that allow the process to accelerate naturally.

Looking Below the Surface: The Problem Tree

- **The leaves** — visible outcomes like disruptive behavior, dropout, or social conflict
- **The trunk** — the identified problem, such as low self-esteem or fear of failure
- **The roots** — the deep, often invisible causes: family stress, social isolation, a previous experience of humiliation in sport, cultural pressure, or a learning difference that was never identified

When a child is consistently difficult in training, the leaf is the behavior. But the roots are almost always more complex and more structural than they first appear. As coaches, we are not therapists — and we are not expected to solve problems that extend far beyond the gym. But we do need to be curious enough to look below the surface, and compassionate enough to resist quick judgments.

Case Study: Sam, Jordan, and the Sled Push

Setting: A commercial gym hosting a youth functional fitness class. Sam (13) and Jordan (12) are partnered for a timed workout that includes a challenging sled push and box jumps.

The Challenge: Sam struggles with the heavy sled and starts falling behind. Overwhelmed and embarrassed, Sam gets visibly frustrated — kicks a cone across the turf and shouts at Jordan, blaming Jordan for "rushing" and being unsupportive.

The SEL Intervention — using the Behavior-Impact-Do feedback model:

- **Behavior:** "Sam, I saw you kick the cone and heard you shout at Jordan when the sled push got difficult."
- **Impact:** "When you react that way, it breaks down the teamwork and makes your partner feel disrespected — which affects the environment we're all trying to build here."
- **Do:** "We all get frustrated when a workout is tough. What's one way to handle that stress next time — and what can you do right now to make it right with Jordan?"

Through this short conversation, Sam recognised his real emotion was embarrassment (self-awareness) and practised calming down before speaking (self-management). He realised Jordan hadn't been

malicious (social awareness), approached Jordan to apologise (relationship skills), and made a conscious choice to respond differently (responsible decision-making).

Coaching Behaviours & Reflective Practice

YOUNGSTARS ultimately aims to develop physical literacy, confidence, and autonomous learners across all age groups. This means the coach's role extends far beyond delivering physical exercises. Coaches must intentionally demonstrate behaviours that nurture decision-making, enjoyment, competence, and long-term engagement in physical activity.

Key Coaching Behaviours

Behaviour	Description
Instruction	Instruction remains an important behaviour, particularly when introducing new skills and ensuring safety. Clear, concise, and age-appropriate instruction helps children understand what is expected of them. However, instruction should not dominate a session. Over-instruction can limit exploration and independence. Coaches should provide just enough information to allow the child to begin the task and allow learning to develop through experience.
Silence	Silence is a powerful but often underused coaching tool. By stepping back and allowing moments without intervention, coaches provide space for children to think, problem-solve, and self-correct. This promotes autonomy and ownership of learning. Silence also allows coaches to observe more effectively and gather information about each child's needs.
Guided Discovery	Rather than telling children exactly what to do, the coach creates challenges or situations that encourage children to find solutions themselves. This approach enhances engagement, creativity, and deeper learning.
Questioning	Effective questioning encourages thinking and reflection. Open-ended questions such as "What did you notice?" or "How could you make that easier?" promote understanding and awareness. Questioning also gives children a voice in the session, making them active participants rather than passive recipients.
Observation	Observation underpins all effective coaching. Coaches must constantly observe to understand each child's ability, confidence level, and emotional state. Without observation, coaching becomes generic rather than individualised.
Feedback and Reinforcement	Positive and timely feedback helps children understand what they are doing well and how they can improve. Feedback should focus on effort, strategy, and progress rather than just outcomes. This supports a growth mindset and builds resilience. Reinforcement helps strengthen desired behaviours — verbal praise, recognition, or simply acknowledging effort.
Differentiation	Children develop at different rates physically, cognitively, and emotionally. Coaches must adapt tasks to ensure every child is appropriately challenged and able to experience success.
Motivation	Coaches play a significant role in shaping a child's fulfilment and enjoyment. Motivation should focus on intrinsic factors such as enjoyment, personal progress, and effort rather than external rewards alone.
Goal Setting	Goal setting helps children develop focus and ownership. Goals should be specific, achievable, and individual. Involving children in the goal-setting process increases commitment and motivation.
Modelling	Coaches serve as role models, not only demonstrating physical skills but also behaviours such as respect, effort, and positive attitude. Children learn as much from what coaches do as from what they say.

Reflective Practice

High-quality coaching is dependent on a coach's ability to reflect on their experiences, develop knowledge, and adapt their behaviors to meet athlete needs. A coach who actively engages in reflective practice is more likely to foster an environment of trust, motivation, and high performance. Reflective practice is not only a tool for personal and professional development but also a mechanism for enhancing Youngstar outcomes.

Reflective practice can be divided into two key forms: reflection in action and reflection on action.

Reflection In Action

Reflection in action occurs during the coaching process. It involves real-time thinking, allowing the coach to adapt and respond to situations as they unfold. For example, during a HYROX-specific circuit, a coach might notice an athlete struggling with their sled pull technique. The coach may question their initial method and finds an appropriate moment within the session to adapt their coaching style to help the athlete form a new and improved approach with the workout station.

Reflection On Action

Reflection on action takes place after the coaching session or competition has concluded. It involves reviewing what happened, analysing the reasons behind success or failure, and planning improvements for future sessions. For example, a coach reviewing a training session and realizing that their strategy for pacing didn't fulfil the Youngstar's potential, which led to a reduced overall performance and enjoyment of the session.

Coaches who model a reflective mindset encourage Youngstars to do the same. When Youngstars are taught to reflect on their own training — considering what went well, what could improve, and how they felt — they begin to take greater ownership of their development. This fosters qualities like resilience, autonomy, and intrinsic motivation.

Reflective Questions — In Action (During Session)

- What am I noticing about the Youngstar's body language or effort right now?
- Is my current approach helping or hindering performance?
- Do I need to intervene immediately, or would stepping back be more beneficial?
- How can I rephrase my coaching cue to make it clearer or more impactful?
- Are the Youngstars still engaged, or do I need to modify the task to re-focus them?

Reflective Questions — On Action (After Session)

- What went well in the session, and why?
- Were there any moments where I could have supported the Youngstar(s) better?
- How did my planning align with the actual execution?
- What feedback did I give, and how was it received?
- What will I change in my next session based on today's experience?

Designing a 45- or 60-Minute HYROX Kids Session

Effective HYROX Kids sessions do not happen by chance. Behind every energetic, purposeful session lies a deliberate structure that balances physical challenge with fun, learning with doing, and effort with reflection. The way a session is designed directly determines whether children leave feeling capable, confident, and eager to return — or disengaged and unsure of their place in the activity.

The LFTD (Lifted) training philosophy — built on the principles of Versatile, Playful, Progressive, and Functional movement — provides the pedagogical backbone for this approach. It recognises that children are not miniature adults. Their development requires age-appropriate intensity, varied stimuli, and learning experiences that feel meaningful rather than mechanical.

Session Structure

Phase	60-Minute Session	45-Minute Session	Intensity	TGfU Focus
Warm-Up	10 min — Playful activation	8–10 min — Shorten game to 1–2 rounds	Low	Activation
Main Activity (Functional Circuit)	20 min — 2–3 rounds, 6–8 stations	15 min — 2 rounds, 5–6 stations	Medium–High	Problem-solving
Endurance / Game Phase	20 min — 4 rounds or 4×3 min game	12–15 min — 3 rounds or 3×3 min game	Medium–High	Game-centred
Cool-Down	10 min — Stretch + reflection	8 min — Shorter stretch, same reflection	Low	Reflection

Success Criteria: What Does a Good HYROX Kids Session Look Like?

Criterion	What it Looks Like
1. Every child is active and included	No child is standing idle for extended periods · Modifications to space, equipment, or rules ensure meaningful participation at all ability levels · Group formats (pairs, small teams) provide natural support structures
2. Movement has context and purpose	Skills are practised within game or challenge scenarios — not in isolation · Children understand why they are doing what they are doing · The physical task is embedded within a meaningful problem to solve
3. Intensity is appropriate and progressive	The session follows a clear arc: activation → build → peak → recovery · Work-to-rest ratios are adapted to the age group (e.g. 40 sec./20 sec. for ages 10–12; 50 sec./10 sec. for ages 14–16) · Children feel physically challenged without being overwhelmed
4. Reflection is built in — not bolted on	The Cool-Down phase includes a structured reflection moment · Open-ended questions are used to encourage children to verbalise their experience · Coaches observe and listen — not just demonstrate and correct
5. The coach facilitates, not just instructs	Questions replace or supplement direct commands wherever possible · Children are given agency to solve problems, make decisions, and adapt strategies · Positive reinforcement focuses on effort, improvement, and teamwork — not only on performance outcomes
6. The session is adaptable and scalable	Coaches use the differentiation framework (rest time, rounds, exercise choice, course length) to adjust on the fly · Beginners and advanced participants can work within the same session structure · The session plan is a guide — not a rigid script

The success of a HYROX Kids session is not measured solely by how much physical work was completed. It is measured by how many children felt included, challenged, and capable. It is measured by the questions they ask, the problems they solve, and the smiles they leave with.

The best HYROX Kids session is not the most intense one — it is the one every child wants to come back to.